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Germ brings end-to-end encrypted messages to Bluesky

A new startup called [Germ](#) is bringing end-to-end encrypted messaging to the Bluesky social network, allowing its users to have a more secure option for chats than [Bluesky's existing DMs](#). After over two years of development, the service is [launching](#) its encrypted DMs for Bluesky into beta this week, with plans to gradually onboard new testers ahead of a public launch.

In time, the [technology that Germ is building](#), much of which is open sourced, could allow Bluesky to introduce encrypted messaging into its own app.

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Germ was designed to offer an alternative to existing end-to-end encrypted platforms that dominate globally, like iMessage, Signal, and WhatsApp. Germ takes advantage of newer technologies, like Messaging Layer Security (MLS), a new standard approved by the [Internet Engineering Task Force](#) (IETF), and the [AT Protocol](#) (or ATProto), which powers Bluesky.

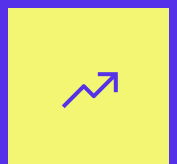
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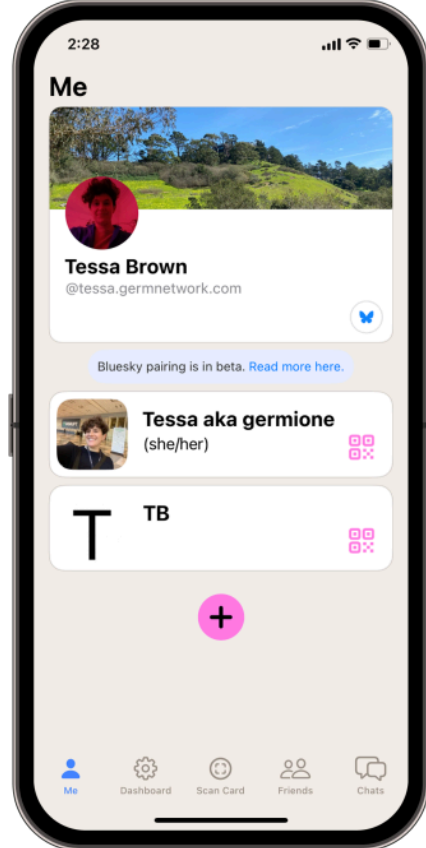


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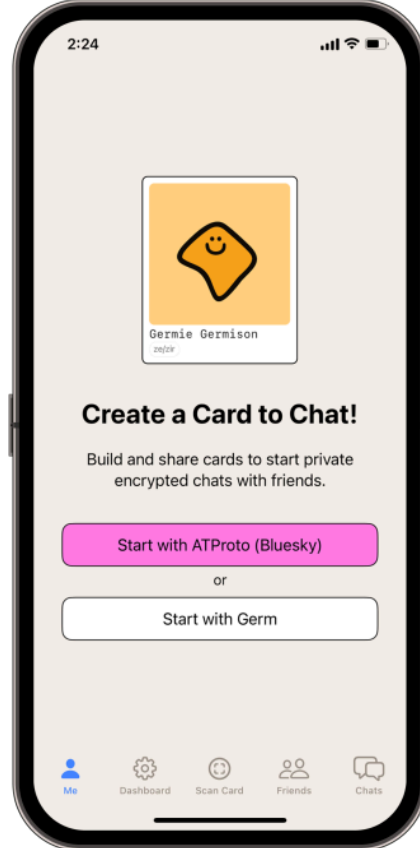


IMAGE CREDITS:GERM

However, instead of requiring a user's phone number as some messaging apps do, Germ integrates with ATProto. This allows Germ users to securely chat with friends from Bluesky and the wider open social web, including apps like [Flashes](#) and [Skylight](#), but with added controls over the user experience.

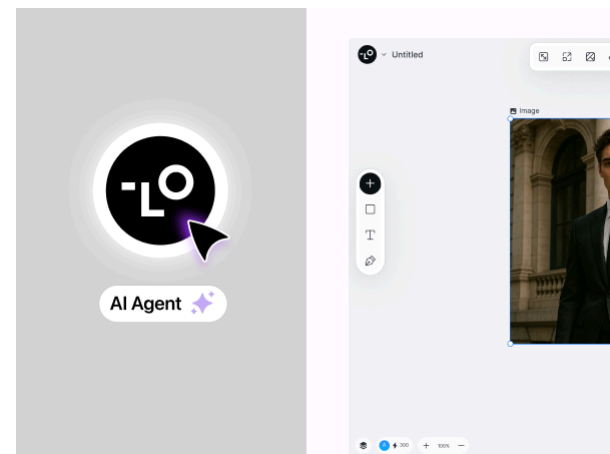
For instance, you can choose to accept DMs from people you follow on Bluesky, or you could configure it so that only you can initiate chats with other people. Plus, when you block a user in Germ, you can choose to block them only in Germ or block them across Bluesky and other ATProto-powered apps as well.

The concept for Germ comes from co-founders [Tessa Brown](#) (CEO), a communications scholar who previously taught at Stanford, and [Mark Xue](#), who worked as a privacy engineer at Apple on technologies like FaceTime and iMessage.

Brown's studies led her to realize that access to private communications was fundamental to the

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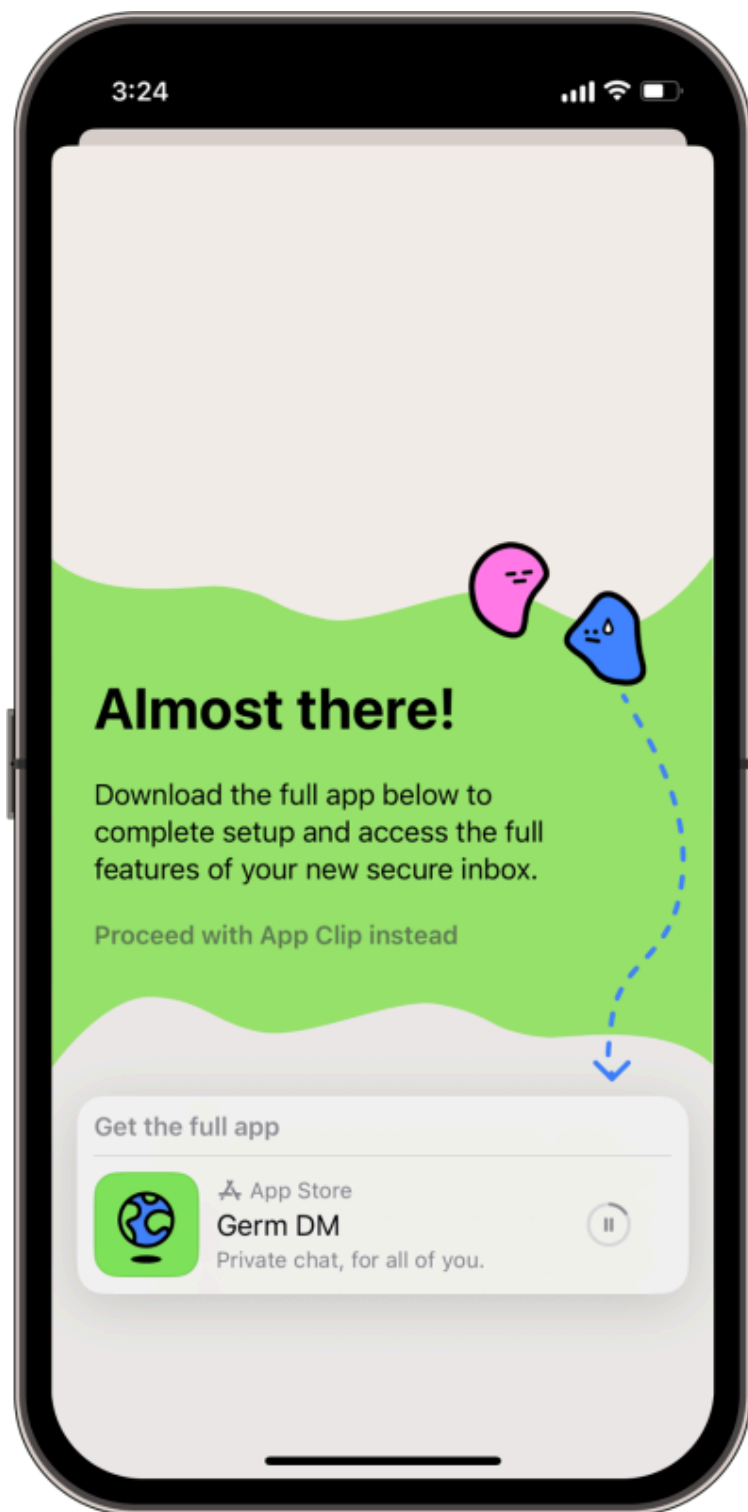


IMAGE CREDITS:GERM

“We know that, psychologically, you can’t build a good relationship with people if you feel like you’re being stared at and manipulated all the time. And that’s really what social media is today,” Brown tells TechCrunch. “So I came out of that work with a really strong conviction around end-to-end encrypted messaging as kind of the centerpiece of what I thought was the future of social media and the future of communication,” she adds.

Xue, meanwhile, came out of Apple believing that the use of phone numbers and telephony is a dated technology to serve as the basis for secure communications and wanted to build something new.

Today, Germ’s service works by way of a “magic link,” which is generated for you and pasted into your Bluesky bio. When another Bluesky user on iOS clicks this link, they can immediately chat with you without downloading a new app from the App Store. To make this possible, Germ takes advantage of underutilized Apple technology called App Clips, which allow users to run a portion of an app’s code on their device without installing the full app.

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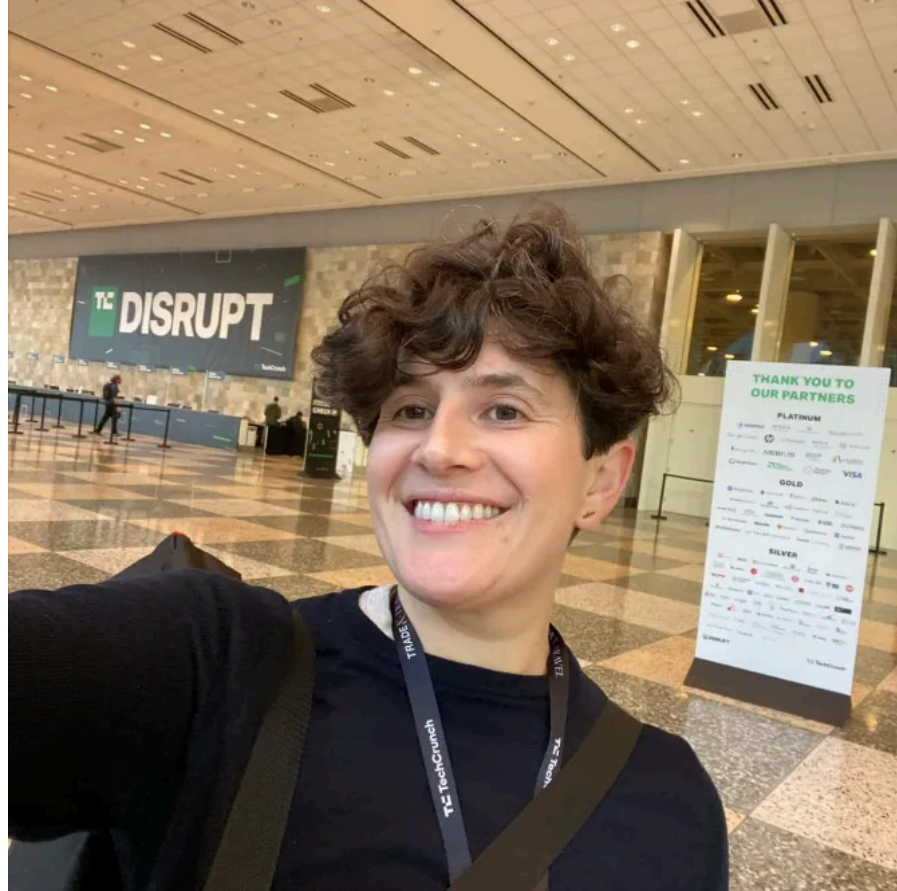
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Today, App Clips are used for miscellaneous one-off-type transactions, like paying for parking via a QR code. But in Germ’s case, they allow for quick chats.

While the user experience is simple enough, the technology behind it is not. The link itself is actually a cryptographic key that authenticates the user’s ATProto identity to confirm that the user is the person associated with that Bluesky handle.

From the Germ App Clip, you can choose to [install the Germ iOS app](#), which offers more controls, access to your friends list, and now Bluesky pairing.

The pairing feature was somewhat finicky in our tests, but we are running the iOS 26 developer beta, which may be causing complications. (To work around the issue, we started the chat from the App Clip first, before trying to authenticate from the installed app.)



TESSA BROWN, GERM NETWORK CEO.

IMAGE CREDITS: [GERM NETWORK INSTAGRAM](#)

Brown tells TechCrunch that she's excited about building within the Bluesky community, given the app's growing cultural impact, which has attracted big names in U.S. politics, like [Barack Obama](#), [Hillary Clinton](#), and other [representatives, senators, and governors](#), to join.

Given that Germ is ahead of the Bluesky team in building encrypted messaging technology, Brown is hopeful that Germ's protocol could be more broadly adopted by Bluesky and others in the future.

While currently free to use, the Germ app may later introduce a premium subscription upgrade that offers more advanced services, including private AI services, personalization tools, and more.

The four-person startup has raised pre-seed funding from angel investors, including a co-author of MLS and other trust and safety experts. Institutional investors include K5 Global and Mozilla

Ventures. The company hopes to raise additional funds for an Android version in the future.

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Sarah Perez

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Sarah has worked as a reporter for TechCrunch since August 2011. She joined the company after having...

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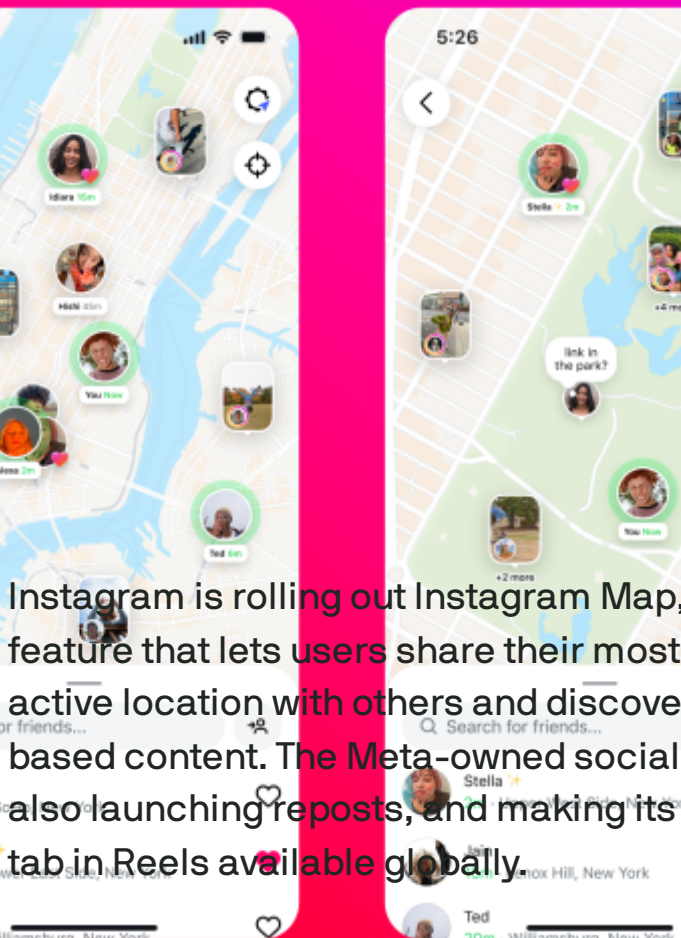
APPS



Instagram takes on
Snapchat with new

'Instagram Map'

Aisha Malik — 7:00 AM PDT · August 6, 2025



Instagram is rolling out Instagram Map, a new feature that lets users share their most recent active location with others and discover location-based content. The Meta-owned social network is also launching reposts, and making its “Friends” tab in Reels available globally.

With its new map feature, Instagram is copying yet another popular feature from Snapchat, after cloning the app’s core Stories functionality [back in 2016](#). Instagram is coming for Snap Map’s crown, a feature that recently surpassed 400 million monthly active users and remains one of the app’s core offerings.

Instagram notes that location sharing is off by default on Instagram Map, and a user’s location only updates when they open the app, meaning it doesn’t provide real-time location updates. Snap Map, on the other hand, allows users to choose whether their location is updated only when they open the app or in real time.

It’s worth noting that Instagram does offer [real-time location sharing via DMs](#) (direct messages). However, unlike Apple’s Find My and Snap Map, which let you share your location with others indefinitely, Instagram only lets users do so for up to one hour.

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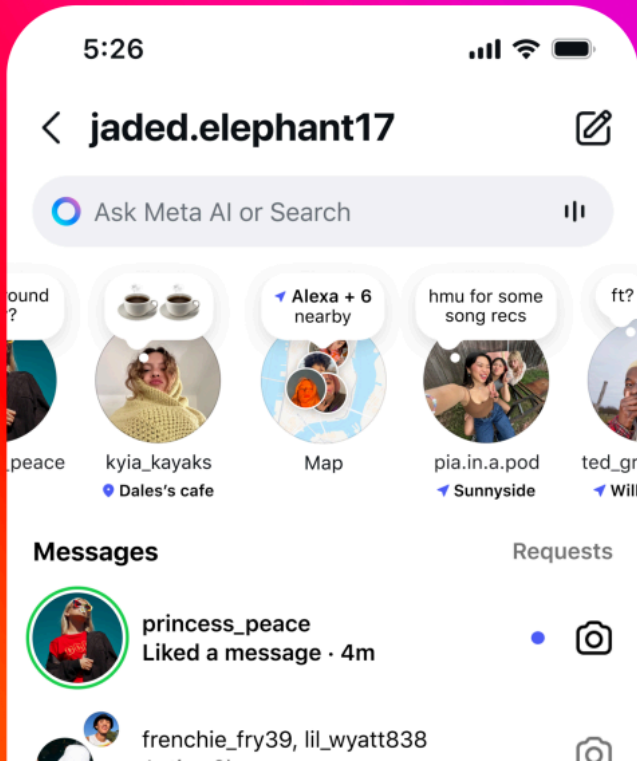


IMAGE CREDITS: INSTAGRAM

Instagram says the new map feature will make it easier for friends to coordinate and link up for hangouts. It also lets users explore location-based content that their friends and favorite creators have shared or engaged with. For example, if your friend attends a nearby music festival and posts a story while there, it will appear on the map. Similarly, if a creator posts a reel about a new restaurant in your city, you'll be able to discover it on Instagram Map.

Regardless of whether you choose to share your location, you can use the map to explore location-based content, Instagram says.

The map also allows users to leave short messages, or "[Notes,](#)" on the map for others to see. Instagram Notes are currently the short messages that appear at the top of your direct messaging feed, but with the launch of Instagram Map, users can now post these short updates on the map.

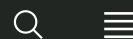
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Although Instagram is certainly taking on Snapchat with this new feature, it also has the opportunity to appeal to people who were fans of [Zenly](#), a social map app that Snap acquired and then shut down in 2023.

The new map feature is launching in the United States starting Wednesday, with broader global availability coming soon. Users can find the Instagram Map at the top of their DM inbox.

The launch doesn't come as a surprise, as [Instagram was spotted developing](#) the map feature

last year.



IMAGE CREDITS: INSTAGRAM

As for the new “Reposts” feature, Instagram is taking a page out of [TikTok’s book](#) while also creating its own version of the popular “retweet” function from Twitter (now X).

This feature lets Instagram users repost public reels and feed posts. These reposts may show up in their friends’ feeds and will also be displayed in a new “Reposts” tab on their profile. Instagram says the new feature gives users a way to share their interests with others and also offers creators the opportunity to reach a wider audience.

To repost a reel or post, users tap the repost icon. Users can also choose to add a note to the repost by typing into the thought bubble that appears on screen and pressing save.

Regarding the new “Friends” tab in Reels, Instagram launched it in the United States earlier this year and is now making it available globally. The tab lets you see public reels that your friends have liked, commented on, reposted, and created.

For users who want to browse and interact with content privately, Instagram is rolling out the ability to opt out of having content you’ve engaged with shown in the friends tab.

Users can hide their likes, comments, and reposts from the tab. Additionally, they can choose to mute likes, comments, and reposts from specific people they follow.

Topics: [Apps](#) [Instagram](#) [instagram map](#) [Snap Map](#)

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Aisha Malik

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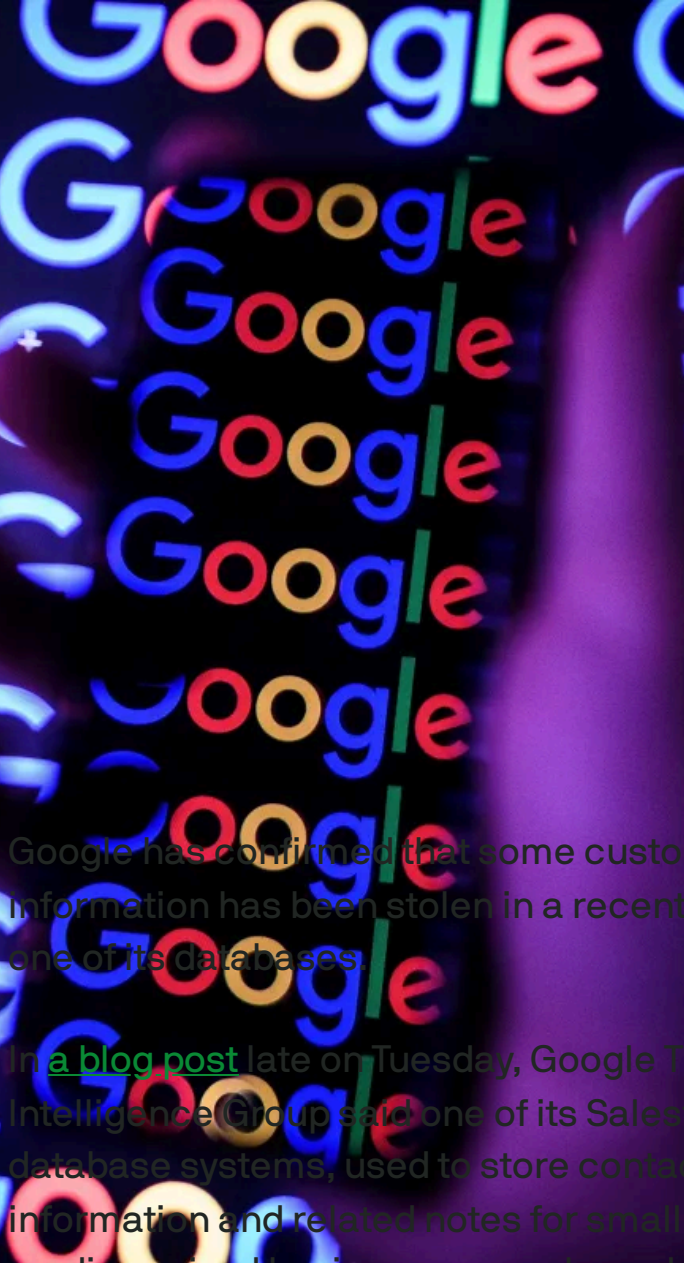
Aisha is a consumer news reporter at TechCrunch. Prior to joining the publication in 2021, she was a telecom reporte...

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SECURITY





Google says hackers stole its customers' data by breaching its Salesforce database

Zack Whittaker — 5:05 AM PDT · August 6, 2025

Google has confirmed that some customers' information has been stolen in a recent breach of one of its databases.

In a [blog post](#) late on Tuesday, Google Threat Intelligence Group said one of its Salesforce database systems, used to store contact information and related notes for small and medium-sized businesses, was breached by a hacking group popularly known as ShinyHunters, formally designated as UNC6040.

IMAGE CREDITS: LEON NEAL / GETTY IMAGES

"The data retrieved by the threat actor was confined to basic and largely publicly available business information, such as business names and contact details," the company said.

Google did not disclose how many customers are affected, and Google spokesperson Mark Karayan declined to comment beyond the company's blog post. It's not clear if the company has received any communication, such as a ransom demand.

ShinyHunters is known for targeting big companies and their cloud-based databases.

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This is the latest in a series of breaches targeting Salesforce cloud systems, after recent thefts of [customer data from Cisco](#) and [airline giant Qantas](#), [retail giant Pandora](#), among others, as [reported by Bleeping Computer](#). According to Google's blog post, the ShinyHunters group relies on voice phishing techniques to trick company employees into granting them access to their cloud-based Salesforce databases.

Google said the ShinyHunters group is likely preparing a data leak site, which some ransomware gangs use to publish stolen data to [extort their corporate victims](#) into paying a ransom. The group is said to have overlaps with other groups, [including The Com](#), a known collective of cybercriminals who use hacking, extortion, and sometimes threats of violence to break into networks.

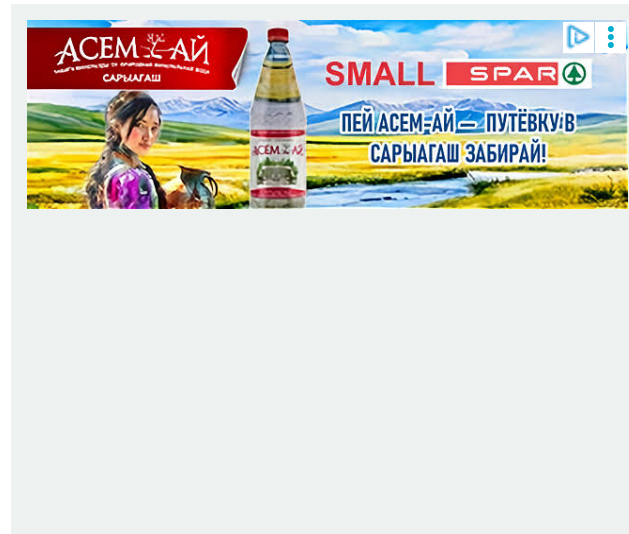
*Do you know more about the Google data breach?
Have you been notified by Google? Securely
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Updated with response from Google.

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